

Wanted: Total OVERHAUL

After Mumbai, the nation's intelligence and security apparatus stand exposed. Radical changes must be implemented in a time-bound manner.

By Bhavna Vij-Aurora, Sandeep Unnithan and Amarnath K. Menon

If politicians, more than Pakistan, have faced the brunt of public ire after the brazen terror acts in Mumbai, it is hardly surprising, especially when solemn promises made by even India's chief executive remain largely unfulfilled. Just three days before the attacks, at a conference of state police heads, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh had lamented the lack of progress on a mission he had announced in October 2005 to empower and equip the police to effectively tackle terrorism and beef up internal security. That mission, if completed, may have helped avert the mayhem that just 10 terrorists could unleash in Mumbai on November 26. Yet as with everything in the Indian Government, accountability is missing as is punitive action for those who failed.

Finally, when heads began to roll with home minister Shivraj Patil and Maharashtra chief

minister Vilasrao Deshmukh getting the boot, the criticism was that it was too little too late.

The new Union Home Minister P. Chidambaram has begun work in earnest by holding regular meetings with his ministry's top officials and also heads of the country's security and intelligence apparatus, including National Security Adviser (NSA) M.K. Narayanan. The attacks in Mumbai exposed just how vulnerable India was and how deep the rot had set in. Whether intelligence agencies failing to process the leads and thwart the attack, anti-terrorist squads unable to respond rapidly and effectively to minimise casualties when the strike began, an ill-equipped and poorly-trained city police force who were helpless bystanders or ineffective laws that actually emboldened terrorists instead of deterring them, it is apparent that the system needs a total overhaul. The Mumbai attack was un-



MANDAR DEODHAR

The action **PLAN**

- **No clemency for terror**
Amendment to the law to ensure no clemency for those on death row
- **Homeland Security**
Setting up of an integrated Department of Homeland Security
- **Terror Laws**
Introduction of stringent laws like POTA with clauses to prevent misuse
- **Mega City Policing**
In major metros, independent police fortresses